

MUMBAI

Rise of the Phoenix

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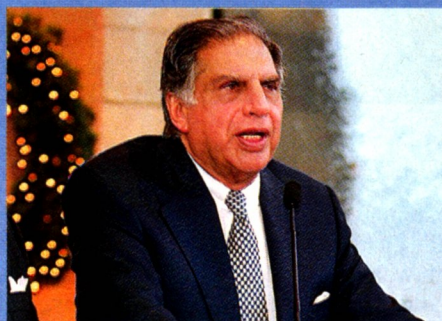
per cent
decrease is
expected
in the
occupancy
rate of The
Trident.

Twenty-five days after terrorists wreaked havoc in their complexes, the Taj Mahal Palace and Tower and the Trident hotels opened their doors for guests once again. The Trident's reopening was marked by a prayer meeting attended by Maharashtra Chief Minister Ashok Chavan and Deputy Chief Minister Chhagan Bhujbal. The Taj, on the other hand, had guests comprising entrepreneurs and celebrities while regular patrons could be seen queuing outside the restaurants. At the reopening, all the 592 staffers of the hotel who were on duty on November 26 received thunderous applause from the guests. "The Taj has been reopened, after a massive concerted effort, in dedication to all those who lost their lives in the attacks on Mumbai," said Ratan Tata, chairman, Taj Group of Hotels. A memorial called The Tree of Life was also unveiled, with the names of the 31 people who were killed at the hotel inscribed at its base. For both the hotels, the going may not be quite easy. "The bookings are slow but encouraging. A hundred rooms have been booked at the hotel," said Rattan Keswani, president, The Trident. While the Oberoi will take several months to reopen, a part of the heritage wing of the Taj Mahal

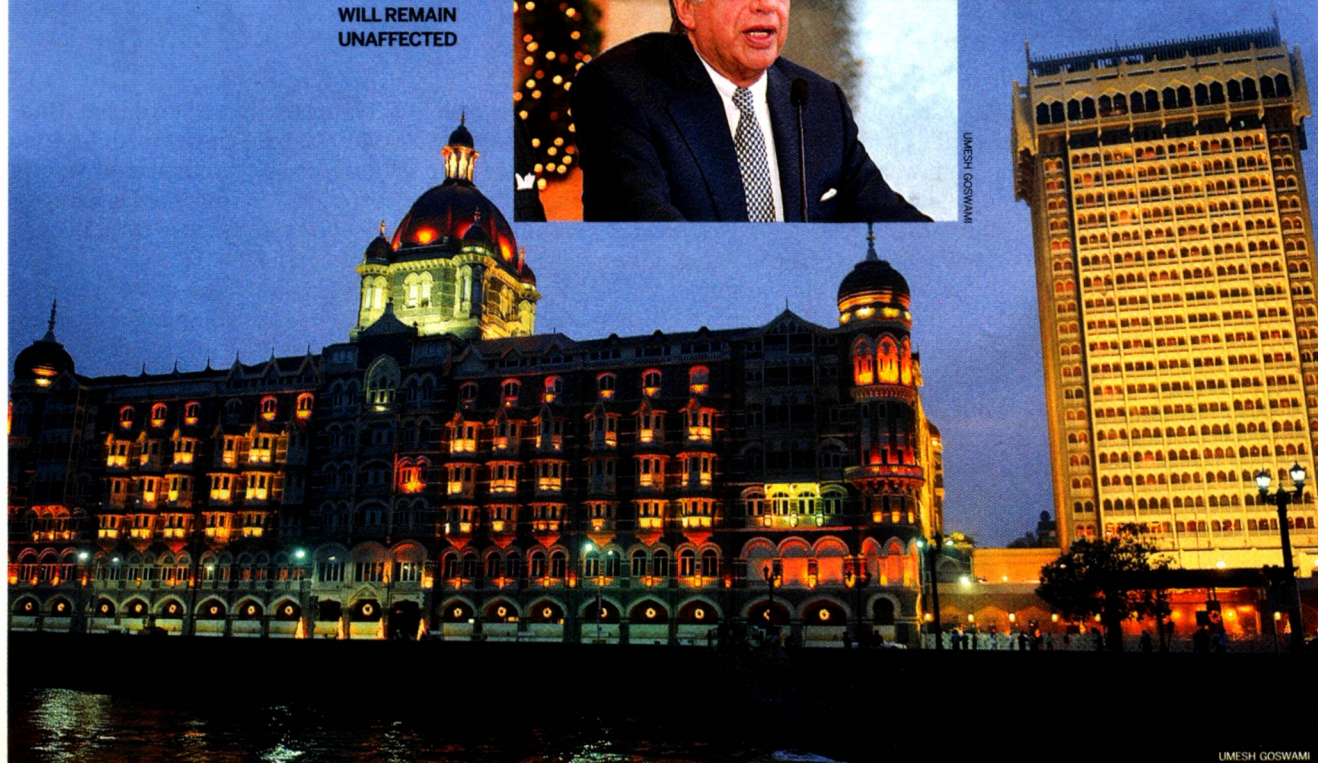
will reopen in
March 2009.

by Nikita Jain

RATAN TATA
(RIGHT) HOPES
THAT THE TAJ'S
OCCUPANCY
WILL REMAIN
UNAFFECTED



UMESH GOSWAMI



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